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In The Name of the Stranger: An Unlikely Resemblance Between the Japanese-American and Northern Irish Communities

Racism and xenophobia are not unique to one singular group of immigrants or migrants, to one singular race or ethnicity. Different historic instances of racism can be proven to be more similar to each other than one might think. The novel *No-No Boy* by John Okada focuses on Ichiro Yamada's life as a Japanese American citizen after being imprisoned for draft evasion, as interpreted by law. Meanwhile, the film *In The Name of the Father* by Jim Sheridan, based on the autobiography *Proved Innocent* by Gerry Conlon, focuses on the Northern Irish Conlon's fight for freedom after being falsely convicted of terrorism in England. *No-No Boy* and *In The Name of the Father* are similar to each other because Ichiro and Conlon are both treated as second-class citizens by the lawmakers of their own home countries and face intergenerational and intercultural conflict. While the Asian Ichiro's discrimination is racial and the white Conlon's is largely religious, both characters suffer due to the actions of the IRA and the Japanese kamikaze pilots respectively despite not being involved with either of them; further, both their relationships with their parents are shaped by the hostile environments that they are subjected to.

Both Gerry Conlon and Ichiro Yamada have been made to suffer from legal persecution at the hands of the British and American legal forces respectively. Despite being a citizen of the United Kingdom (as Northern Ireland is part of the United Kingdom), Conlon, who was wrongfully convicted for the 1974 Guildford pub bombing alongside several others, is singled out for his Catholic faith and Northern Irish nationality whilst living in England. *In The Name of the Father* documents the torture Gerry Conlon especially was subjected to at the hands of the law even in the courtroom. When a police inspector testifying against Conlon is questioned over

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whether there is enough evidence against them, he responds, “I have the confessions of four obvious terrorists. What more do you want?” (Sheridan, *In The Name of the Father*). Conlon’s treatment by the British police reflects the persecution that the Northern Irish community faced at the time, which was also attributed to the religious conflict between Catholics and Protestants in the United Kingdom. Bohdan Vysloužil of the University of Pardubice, the Czech Republic, examines the historical roots of the Catholic-Protestant conflict between Northern Ireland and England in his thesis. Having faced relative peace until the late 1960s, the Troubles - the long-running conflict between the largely Catholic Irish Republican Army (IRA) and largely Protestant forces (especially troops from England) - began largely due to anti-Catholic employment discrimination. During the Troubles, the British legal system carried out documented miscarriages of justice. According to Vysloužil, the Irish were treated as “stupid, drunk and violent Catholics” and were often held in high-security situations, many as “political prisoners” (25). Additionally, crucial information that could have potentially exonerated Conlon and his fellow wrongful inmates had been withheld. The information was only uncovered when lawyer Gareth Peirce happened upon it, revealed it to the prosecution and thus, set Conlon free. Given their religious-based nature, the gross legal injustices that Conlon is subjected to are comparable, but not entirely identical, to those that Ichiro Yamada faced in Okada’s *No-No Boy*.

Ichiro’s mistreatment by the law, as a so-called “no-no boy,” is based on his race rather than his religion. Many Japanese Americans were incarcerated after the bombing of Pearl Harbor and placed into concentration camps, regardless of whether they were lawful U.S. citizens. Ruth Ozeki, who wrote the foreword of *No-No Boy*’s 2014 edition, detailed this discrimination by

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referring to Lieutenant General John DeWitt: ““A Jap’s a Jap. It makes no difference if he’s an American citizen or not”” (X). Japanese American men were made to fill out a form pledging allegiance to the United States; two particular questions asked whether 1) if they were willing to serve in the American army at its own will, and 2) if they would pledge absolute allegiance to the United States at the expense of their loyalty to Japan. Those who answered no to both were branded “no-no boys,” and were all incarcerated, as was Ichiro. Upon their eventual release, many were alienated from society, as was Ichiro. His sentiments are best encapsulated when he reflects to himself immediately after his release: “Best thing I can do would be to kill some son of a bitch and head back to prison” (Okada 3). Ichiro is understandably jaded: his society ostracizes him not only because of his race but because of his perceived disloyalty to his adopted home country and his refusal to comply with the law, like a member of the Asian “model minority.” Ichiro’s position in society is similar, in a manner of speaking, to Gerry Conlon’s. Ichiro was oppressed due to the actions of the Japanese kamikaze pilots who bombed Pearl Harbor in 1941, despite having long been an American citizen. Meanwhile, Conlon was treated as an IRA terrorist, despite not being affiliated at all with them; his suffering at the hands of the British legal system was ultimately rooted in the entrenched Protestant-Catholic conflict. The two men faced discrimination for different reasons, but they ultimately suffered similar kinds of discrimination and faced similar after-effects of that discrimination.

Another key element that makes Ichiro and Conlon’s situations ultimately similar to each other is that of the intergenerational and intercultural conflict they face in the United States and England respectively. Ichiro’s conflict with his parents is based not only on their generational

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differences but also on their cultural differences, which contribute to Ichiro's sense of alienation in society. This is especially evident in Ichiro's relationship with his mother, whom Ozeki describes as "liv[ing] inside the delusion that Japan has won the war" (XI). Mrs. Yamada is under this delusion because, having migrated to the United States later in life, she is still allegiant to Japan and has difficulty letting go of the country that she grew up in. Ichiro, meanwhile, has grown up in the United States as an American citizen - but despite this, his mother's pro-Japanese views have left him deeply conflicted about his status. As an American citizen, he does not fit into the Asian "model minority" mold because he rejects that his internment was just: "We'll forget the two years in camp because anybody can see it was all a mistake and you didn't really mean to do it and I'm all yours" (Okada 32). However, he does not call himself completely Japanese either, as part of him yearns to be accepted into American society: "...he saw groups of young Japanese wasting away the night as nights were meant to be wasted by young Americans..." (Okada 33). Ichiro's conflicted sense of self does not help his relationship with his mother, who does not understand why her son's attitude regarding his identity is not the same as hers. She remains loyal to her country of birth, while he struggles between the *country* he was raised in and the *culture* he was raised in - two very different things in his experience. This particular conflict resembles the intergenerational and intercultural conflict faced by Gerry Conlon, whose pursuit of a bohemian life in London clashes with his family's Catholic beliefs, but does not spare him from the ill-treatment he receives from the British law enforcement.

One reason Conlon goes to London is to seek freedom from his father Giuseppe, a traditionalist Catholic who wants his son to lead a conventional life. The younger Conlon openly

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rejects Giuseppe's religious beliefs, spending his days committing petty crimes. On a rare phone call, Giuseppe asks Gerry if he has been attending church. Gerry lies: "Aye, every Sunday. Like clockwork" (Sheridan, *In The Name of the Father*). Like Ichiro and his mother, the chasm between father and son is attributable to differences in both religion and age; their relationship is also warped by the hostile environment they face in England. A 1994 review by Martin McLoone argues that when he is first imprisoned, Gerry misguidedly looks to two other men as father figures: first Inspector Dixon, who later unabashedly testifies against the Guildford Four and Maguire Seven in court. Later, he is swayed by Joe McAndrew of the IRA, but that is destroyed when the militant's "single-minded attachment to physical violence" (McLoone 45) ultimately turns Gerry against him. Gerry is set apart from his own father, and now inmate, whose passive response to being wrongfully imprisoned causes Gerry to break from him. Gerry, desperate to fight against being perceived as a terrorist, is swayed by the influences that surround him at first. In the end, he comes to accept his father's way of thinking. While it does not stop him from fighting for justice, it gives him a new perspective: "The moral strength of Giuseppe's pacifist resistance to the injustice is finally recognized by the prodigal son. There is no moral ambiguity in Gerry's acquiescence to his father's will" (McLoone 45). Gerry and his father's reconciliation sets them apart from Ichiro and his mother, the latter of whom takes her own life more distant from her son than ever. Ichiro, in turn, is left with the knowledge that his mother never understood him. However, Gerry and Giuseppe Conlon came very close to ending up in that situation, as soon after Gerry came to understand his father, Giuseppe died.

In conclusion, Jim Sheridan's film *In The Name of the Father* and John Okada's novel

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No-No Boy are similar to one another because of the struggles both of their protagonists go through. Gerry Conlon and Ichiro Yamada face religious and racial discrimination respectively at the hands of the law, with almost identical effects. Both their relationships with their parents are also influenced by their experiences in hostile environments; however, while Gerry ultimately gets to resolve his relationship with his father, Ichiro is not so fortunate.

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